

More than Mapping

Joanna Rohlf is a Certified Geographic Information Systems Professional (GISP) and a Certified Floodplain Manager (CFM). She works as a Floodplain Mapping Specialist for the Kansas Department of Agriculture, Division of Water Resources.

Joanna went to a small, rural high school with only 13 students in her graduating class. “I grew up on a crop farm outside a rural community. I helped on the farm growing up, especially during harvest and planting seasons. School was a top priority, so I had to balance that with work throughout high school and college.” After high school, she chose to attend a four-year university, majoring in Journalism. However, Joanna ultimately decided that wasn’t the right path for her and took some classes during the summer before her junior year to help her decide which direction to go. That’s when she recognized her love of geography. She recognized an emerging career path in GIS that would allow her to combine her early loves of math and art.

While working full-time as a GIS Analyst, Joanna chose to earn a Master’s degree online in environmental studies. She did this to open additional career opportunities but notes that “Getting my Master’s while working full-time was very challenging. It helped to have support at home and work, as well as knowing what my class expectations were and how they fit in with my home and work obligations.”

"Skills I use regularly in my job are problem-solving, thinking strategically, and communicating complex information in a way that is easy to understand and digest." Joanna also shares, “I didn’t have much guidance early on in my career and had to figure out a number of things on my own. Now I try to provide that guidance to new hires and offer advice as I can.”

Engineers Changing the World



Joanna Rohlf
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“Clear communication is a very useful skill for any career path. It is not something you need to have as a natural talent, because everyone has to work at it and develop it.”

